Ruy López de Segura — Libro de la invención liberal y arte del juego del axedrez (1561)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Ruy López de Segura (c. 1530–c. 1580), the Spanish priest described in the record as the strongest chess player of his age. In 1561 he published one of the first books on modern chess in Europe, written to refute Damiano, whose chess book had appeared in 1512. López introduced the word *gambit*, and the opening that now bears his own name still carries him into games played today. This dossier keeps his place in that history while claiming nothing further for him here: a complete English translation of his book, by Michael J. McGrath, was published by Catholic University of America Press in 2020, and the record was corrected to say so.

The story

Ruy López de Segura (c. 1530–c. 1580) was a Spanish priest and, in the record's words, the strongest chess player of his age. In 1561, at Alcalá de Henares, he published one of the first books on modern chess in Europe: *Libro de la invención liberal y arte del juego del axedrez*. He wrote it to refute Damiano, whose chess book had appeared in 1512.

The book has four parts. The first gives a general discussion, a history, and the Spanish rules of the day. The second treats openings: López introduces the word

gambit, gives variations of the King's Gambit and the Bishop's Opening, and gives the Steinitz Defence line of the opening that now bears his own name, the Ruy Lopez. The third and fourth parts are a sustained critique of Damiano's games and analysis.

This dossier was first prepared on the understanding that López's book had reached Italian, French, and German readers in its own period, but had never been translated into English. A later, harder check showed that understanding to be wrong. A complete English translation already exists. The candidate was therefore withdrawn.

That withdrawal is the true ending of this story, and this collection counts it as a success of method rather than a failure. A claim was made, the claim was checked more rigorously, the claim did not survive, and the record was corrected instead of being defended. López is not presented here as an open candidate.

The work and what survives

The 1561 Spanish original is in the public domain everywhere. Its length is recorded in two unreconciled forms in this collection. The main text describes the work as about 150 pages. The pinned Internet Archive scan of this same 1561 printing is recorded in the addendum as 326 pages. The two counts are not reconciled in this package, and they are marked UNCHECKED.

The Internet Archive identifier that was at first left open was later pinned and verified: `bub_gb_n3s8AAAAcAAJ`, from a Google Books source. It is the 1561 Alcalá printing, printed by Andrés de Angulo. The pin was verified on the Wikimedia Commons file page of the full-text DjVu, which has 326 pages, was imported from this Internet Archive item through IA-upload in 2019, and records the identifier and source verbatim. That scan pin stands for any other purpose, even though the translation candidate does not.

The period translations recorded are an Italian translation in 1584 and a French translation in the seventeenth century — Sotheby's gives French 1609 and German 1616. The nearest English items found in the original filing were about López rather than by him, including Jaenisch's articles in the *Chess Player's Chronicle* in 1848–49.

Its English fortunes — the premise falsified

The original filing stated: no complete English translation found after research. The second-pass primacy-hardening check, recorded in a dated evening addendum on 14 October 2026, falsified that “never English” premise at full strength.

Michael J. McGrath, translator, *The Art of the Game of Chess*, Catholic University of America Press, 10 July 2020, is a complete scholarly English translation of the whole 1561 book. It runs to 336 pages; its ISBN is 978-0-8132-3281-2; it has a foreword by Andrew Soltis, a critical introduction, and more than 275 footnotes. It was presented by the publisher as the first English translation, and it is treated as the complete treatise rendered by every source consulted. It is in print at $24.95.

Earlier still, J. H. Sarratt's *Works of Damiano, Ruy-Lopez, and Salvio*, published in London in 1813, contains a partial English rendering of López's game material. The Internet Archive identifier for Sarratt's volume is `worksdamianoruy00sigugoog`. It gives 52 numbered games, “translated and arranged” into Sarratt's own scheme, and Part 1 — the history, rules, and discourse — was not translated at all. Murray's *History of Chess*, published in 1913, at page 874, judges Sarratt's translations “careless, inaccurate, and incomplete.”

What remains possible

The disposition is stated in the record without softening: KILLED as a first-translation candidate, following the Kammerer precedent. No form of “first English translation” is available for López.

A future López item could only be an honestly labelled independent re-translation — for example, a free public-domain edition. None is recommended while McGrath's edition is in print. The earlier framing of López as completing a trio with Carrera and Gianutio is retired.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Libro_de_la_invencion_liberal_y_arte_del_juego_del_axedrez
- https://www.sothebys.com/en/buy/auction/2026/books-manuscripts-objects-from-three-important-collections/ruy-lopez-de-sigura-libro-de-la-invencion-liberal (period translation sequence)

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ruy_Lopez (bibliography: 1561 original via IA; Jaenisch articles)